because of their works' closeness to life, sense of reality and certainty about the future. This is a valued contribution which enriches working people's intellectual world, and which they respect and love.

9

In that halcyon year, in which Honecker was also elected chairman of the powerful National Defence Council, new routines emerged. Unlike Ulbricht – who generally neglected the Politburo as a decision-making forum – he raised its status. Hans Modrow, the First Secretary of the SED in Dresden, remembered a much friendlier atmosphere at the Tuesday sessions. However, while Honecker's style of rule had a capacity of self-limitation, pity those who mistook his mildness for weakness, or his quiet for lack of calculation.

During these early days, he attached importance to expert opinion and, according to Heinz Lippmann – who spoke generously about his ability to grasp details and enforce decisions – Honecker could confidently compete with the 'managers of big Western concerns'.10

From the outset, he perfected and systematized routines. Archived agendas show Tuesdays were always busy with the Politburo meeting, followed by a talk with Erich Mielke. Security issues, according to Schabowski, were never discussed in the Politburo: 'From the eight years that I was a member of the Politburo, I don't remember any decision on the work of the State Security. The only thing that required our approval each year was the appointment and promotion of generals.' After meeting Mielke, Honecker discussed the content and sequence of the evening's Aktuelle Kamera TV news. Fancying himself an editor, the new First Secretary routinely infuriated newspaper staff by huffing and puffing over headlines, photographs and features. On some occasions, he involved himself in story conferences through to the final editing.11 In 1976, millions of newspapers were reportedly destroyed an hour after publication when Honecker decided to withdraw his own comments about East Germany spying in West